Science Study Guide: Healthy Teeth and Oral Hygiene

A simple guide to preventing tooth decay and gum disease

1. What is oral hygiene?

Oral hygiene means keeping the mouth, teeth, gums, and tongue clean to help prevent tooth decay, gum disease, bad breath, and oral infections. The mouth naturally contains bacteria. When bacteria mix with food particles—especially sugar—they can form a sticky layer called **plaque**. If plaque is not removed regularly, it can produce acids that damage tooth enamel and cause cavities.

2. Important terms

Term	Meaning
Plaque	A soft, sticky film of bacteria that forms on teeth
Dental caries	Tooth decay or cavities caused by acid damaging the tooth
Enamel	The hard outer protective layer of a tooth
Gingivitis	Early gum inflammation, often causing red, swollen, or bleeding gums
Fluoride	A mineral in many toothpastes that helps strengthen teeth and prevent decay

3. How to brush properly

Brush your teeth **twice daily for at least two minutes**—once in the morning and especially before bed. Use fluoride toothpaste where available. Fluoride helps protect teeth from decay.

1. Put a small amount of fluoride toothpaste on a soft toothbrush.
2. Hold the toothbrush at a gentle angle toward the gumline.
3. Use small, gentle circular movements; do not scrub harshly.
4. Clean the outside, inside, and chewing surfaces of every tooth.
5. Gently brush the tongue to reduce bacteria and bad breath.
6. Spit out excess toothpaste after brushing. Avoid rinsing immediately with lots of water, because this can wash away fluoride left on the teeth.

4. Everyday habits for healthy teeth

• Limit how often you eat or drink sugary snacks, sweets, soft drinks, and sweetened beverages.

• Choose water as your main drink when possible.

• Eat balanced meals that include fruits, vegetables, proteins, and other nutritious foods.

• Clean between teeth daily with floss or an appropriate interdental cleaner if available.

• Replace your toothbrush when the bristles become worn or frayed.

• Visit a dentist for check-ups when possible, even if you do not currently have tooth pain.

5. Warning signs: see a dentist

Seek dental advice if you have toothache or sensitivity that does not go away; bleeding, swollen, painful, or receding gums; persistent bad taste or bad breath; a broken tooth, swelling, pus, or facial swelling; or a mouth sore, white/red patch, or lump lasting longer than two weeks.

Quick self-check

1. Brushing only when your teeth hurt is enough.
2. Plaque can contribute to tooth decay and gum disease.
3. Fluoride toothpaste helps protect teeth from decay.
4. Frequent sugary snacks and drinks can increase the risk of tooth decay.
5. You should clean the inner, outer, and chewing surfaces of your teeth.

Answers: 1. False • 2. True • 3. True • 4. True • 5. True

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